

Chapter 101-1

Liang Shi had no memories of being with her parents—whether in this world or the other one.

But she had her grandparents.

She knew what bonds were, what familial love was.

Especially the kind that transcended blood relations.

Admittedly, she could turn Liang Xinzhou against Qiu Zimin, make him treat her the way he treated Ling Dang, continue standing in front of her while she stood behind him like a coward, letting him resist Qiu Zimin on her behalf, letting him speak harsh words to Qiu Zimin, even severing the mother-son relationship.

This would certainly be painful for Qiu Zimin.

And this would also be the bitter fruit of Qiu Zimin's own evil deeds—raising a son to be so righteous and upstanding.

But what had Liang Xinzhou done wrong?

One cannot choose their parents. Moreover, Qiu Zimin had been beyond reproach to everyone in the Liang family except Liang Shi—at least before Guo Xinran came back.

Time and again, Liang Xinzhou stood before his family members, holding up the sky for them, shielding them from the harsh winds and cold rains outside.

Yet no one had ever thought that Liang Xinzhou was also just a person who needed to draw warmth from others to keep moving forward.

Liang Shi was unwilling to be a coward, unwilling to let Liang Xinzhou become a tool for her revenge.

To be precise, she was unwilling to let anyone become a tool for her retaliation against Qiu Zimin.

A matter between two people should be left for those two people to resolve.

Perhaps this was somewhat naive.

But she felt this naivety was worth preserving.

Facing Liang Xinzhou's astonished expression, Liang Shi smiled even more freely. "Big Brother, if you're tired, step away from these matters. You don't have to protect everyone."

Liang Shi said, "Younger siblings are meant to grow up, you know."

Liang Xinzhou pressed his lips together. His eyes behind his glasses were slightly moist. After a moment of silence, he said in a low voice, "But you're still my younger sibling."

"But what about your wife?" Liang Shi said. "Compared to us, Sister-in-law and the little one in her belly need you more."

Liang Xinzhou frowned. "What about you? What are you going to do?"

"Compared to the past, the present is more important." Liang Shi said something that was a common saying. "I will find out why she did this, and I hope she pays the price for what she's done. People have to pay for their mistakes, right?"

Liang Xinzhou turned around, his fingers tapping on the steering wheel, but without the leisurely rhythm from before. The sounds were rapid and dense, enough to make one feel restless just hearing them.

After a long while, Liang Xinzhou said, "When you need help, just ask."

The implication being—as long as you ask, I will help you.

Liang Shi smiled softly. "Okay."

Chapter 101-2

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The city entered into nighttime. On the asphalt roads, vehicles came and went, red taillights crisscrossing and lighting up throughout the city. The streetlamps on both sides of the road illuminated the way home for people hurrying along.

Ling Dang slept peacefully on Liang Shi's lap as Liang Xinzhou drove Liang Shi back to Chenjiang Community.

Along both banks of the river were dim yellow lights, casting a gentle glow on the flowing water.

The cables spanning the bridge seemed to reach toward the sky. This city was inclusive and beautiful.

They had originally planned to go to the hospital where Qiu Zimin and Guo Xinran were, but Ling Dang was fast asleep, and it was getting late. Liang Shi suggested going home first to avoid having a fight late at night, which would make everyone uncomfortable.

The main reason was to give Liang Xinhe and his wife time to "pull the rug out from under them."¹

Liang Xinzhou also agreed. He dropped her off at the community and asked if she had moved in yet. Liang Shi replied that she would in a while.

When she was about to carry Ling Dang out, Liang Xinzhou told her to leave Ling Dang in the car. Tonight, Ling Dang could stay with him and Yu Wan. Liang Shi hesitated a bit—after all, Yu Wan was pregnant, and she was afraid Ling Dang might disturb her.

So Liang Shi said she would ask Ling Dang's opinion.

Ling Dang was drowsy from sleep. After being woken up, she didn't cry. When she heard Liang Shi ask whether she wanted to go to Auntie's house or back to Uncle's house tonight, Ling Dang rubbed her eyes and asked, "Is Sheng Yu at your house?"

Liang Shi: "...I don't know."

"Then I'm not going." Ling Dang yawned, rather heartlessly. "I want to go find Auntie and play with the little sister in her belly."

Liang Shi: "...Alright then."

After waking Ling Dang up, she didn't let her go back to sleep. The little head huddled in the seat. After reminding Liang Xinzhou to drive carefully, Liang Shi finally headed home.

On her way home, she sent a message to Xu Qingzhu, asking if she had eaten dinner and if she had come back.

After sending the message, she suddenly thought of "roommates sharing a rental." This situation was indeed quite similar.

Living in the same home but in different rooms. The daily questions were: Are you home? Are you at home? What do you want to eat in the morning? What do you want to eat at night?

Occasionally interspersed with some other conversations.

Swaying between crossing the line and not crossing it.

Everything followed the heart's desire. No one deliberately controlled the pace between them, yet occasionally they would rush headlong toward a place where they couldn't stop.

In the moment, it didn't feel like anything was wrong. Instead, her heart would pound, and she could laugh out loud just looking at the screen.

Only afterward would she realize that perhaps she had overstepped.

Standing in the elevator, Liang Shi thought carefully about this issue for the first time.

But she couldn't distinguish where her own feelings stood, or to what degree Xu Qingzhu's feelings had reached.

Was it liking?

Or simply dependence?

Liang Shi was someone extremely skilled at suppressing her own emotions. She had mastered delayed gratification to the extreme.

In that other world, afraid of hurting others, she always had to suppress her emotions. In middle school, when she saw a girl she liked, her first reaction was to stay far away—she wouldn't even have normal conversations with her.

It was the same every time afterward. Even when she met someone she was interested in, she wouldn't take the initiative to greet them. She was exceptionally sensitive and would notice changes in the emotions of people around her.

Because she had always lived this way.

Back then, her manager and assistant both said she lived too cautiously, too carefully—not at all like someone in their twenties.

What should someone in their twenties be like?

Bold and carefree, proud and confident, thinking that no peak in this world was too high, no hardship in this world was too difficult, and nothing could make them retreat.

When doing something, they wouldn't think about how others would feel, but would first consider what they themselves wanted.

But Liang Shi had passed through her twenties without being bold or carefree, without being proud or confident. She was like the most inconspicuous silent pine tree by the roadside—evergreen through all four seasons, always there, yet never noticed by anyone.

Being mature beyond one's years was never something to be glad about.

Manager Sister Wang said Liang Shi was the most worry-free artist she had ever managed.

Assistant Xiao Bai said Liang Shi was the most down-to-earth Best Actress in the entertainment industry.

But Liang Shi's silence only applied to herself. If she was wronged, she would silently endure it.

If she made others uncomfortable, she would actively communicate.

She hoped others wouldn't go to sleep carrying unpleasant emotions.

Once, when Sister Wang heard this, she asked her, "What about you?"

—What about you?

—I've never thought about it.

Liang Shi truly had never thought about this. For her, grievances wouldn't last overnight.

Because no one would carry her grievances, be the trash can she could pour her heart out to, or be her safe harbor.

So she didn't board anyone's ship, yet could still stand brave and resolute in the middle of the ocean, not overturned by the fierce waves.

It was precisely because she was this kind of person that she could understand Liang Xinzhou's current situation, that she could empathize with him.

She would go worship Buddha once a year. Kneeling on the prayer cushion, her wish was always simple: May there be world peace, and may everyone be safe and happy.

Except for the year her grandfather was seriously ill—that time she changed her wish: She hoped her grandfather's illness would get better soon.

Liang Shi still didn't understand her own emotions. She only knew that being with Xu Qingzhu made her happy.

Her whole being would relax.

Because Xu Qingzhu knew all her secrets and had seen her at her worst, she could be herself without restraint in front of Xu Qingzhu.

Only in front of Xu Qingzhu was she still the Liang Shi of before, without needing to live wearing a mask.

Although Zhao Xuning also knew about her situation, they had little interaction, so it wasn't like how she was with Xu Qingzhu.

1. "Pull the rug out from under them" (釜底抽薪): A Chinese idiom literally meaning "to remove the firewood from under the cauldron." It refers to a strategy of removing the source of a problem or cutting off someone's support/resources, thereby fundamentally solving an issue or undermining someone's position. In this context, it means giving Liang Xinhe and his wife time to deal with the root of the problem regarding Qiu Zimin and Guo Xinran. ↩

Chapter 101-3

After thinking for a long time, Liang Shi felt that her attitude toward Xu Qingzhu was probably—indulgence.

She had indulged her own emotions and indulged her somewhat wandering thoughts.

At certain times, she had indulged her own desires.

Whether physical or psychological.

When facing Xu Qingzhu, she wasn't so repressed.

Before she had sorted out her own emotions clearly, or rather, before she had drawn a clear line for her feelings, that strange mechanical voice sounded again in her mind: 【Hello, Host. Your accepted Side Mission 2 (S-rank): Spend 24 hours inseparable from Xu Qingzhu has not been completed. It will expire tomorrow at 23:00. Before 23:00 today, you may choose to...】

The system suddenly froze mid-sentence, and Liang Shi knew why it froze.

When the mission was first issued, it said that after accepting, one could choose to abandon it within 24 hours before the mission ended. But the PS added later said that for dual side missions, once accepted they couldn't be abandoned, and failure to complete would result in a deduction of ten luck points.

The system was still stacking the previous wording, but the rules had changed afterward, so it couldn't sort out the logic anymore.

It had hit a bug right here.

Sure enough, after a moment of silence, the system sounded again: 【Wuwuwu, Little Tong is sad.】

Liang Shi: "....."

She said without mercy, "Speak system-speak."

System: 【?】

"Did you think I would let you speak human language?" Liang Shi said. "If you can't do it, don't try to learn it. What you've learned is neither here nor there."

System: 【.....】

【After just a few days apart, Host, you've actually learned to talk back.】 The system continued speaking in that whimpering tone. 【I so wish Host was still as pure and wonderful as before.】

Liang Shi: "Is there anything else?"

System: 【.....】

Within two seconds, the system immediately became serious: 【Hello, Host. Your...】

It rattled off a whole bunch after that. The gist was that her accepted Side Mission 2 had already started its countdown. This was her last night to complete the mission. If she couldn't complete it, ten luck points would be deducted.

Anyway, this system dragged its feet when giving points in order to make her complete missions more slowly, but was swift and generous when deducting points.

Yet every time it issued a mission, it would say, "Please work hard to complete the mission, Host!"

Work hard... my foot.

Liang Shi was already used to it. She responded with an acknowledgment, and the system disappeared.

After being interrupted by the system like this, Liang Shi couldn't be bothered to think anymore. Every time she thought about her feelings, it always dragged up some unpleasant memories, so she decided to just let nature take its course.

After all, the mission hadn't been completed yet!

Chapter 101-4

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When Liang Shi got back, Xu Qingzhu was in the kitchen.

As if she had discovered a new hobby, Xu Qingzhu had been going to the kitchen more frequently lately.

Often when Liang Shi woke up in the morning, she would find her in the kitchen, always tinkering with some "dark cuisine." However, none of it had been fed to Liang Shi—Xu Qingzhu had probably eaten a little of it herself.

After all, Liang Shi had discovered the remnants of those "dark cuisine" dishes when cleaning up the kitchen.

The benefit of having moved to a new place was that it only took a few steps to get from the entrance to the kitchen.

Night had fallen. Xu Qingzhu stood in front of the counter, her silhouette slender. Hearing the footsteps, she didn't turn around, her cool voice greeting unhurriedly, "You're back?"

Liang Shi responded, "Mm."

"How did you know it was me?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu said, "After living together for so long, I can tell from the sound of your footsteps."

Liang Shi: "....."

She had forgotten that Xu Qingzhu had very good hearing.

Because she had gotten Qi Jiao's diary, Liang Shi's mood wasn't very good. But standing in the kitchen at this moment, with the bright incandescent light shining down, illuminating the entire space as bright as daylight, it also drove away her bad mood. She stepped forward and asked Xu Qingzhu, "What are you planning to make?"

Xu Qingzhu said, "Congee. I bought some vegetables from downstairs."

"Eating so light?" Liang Shi said as she went to lift the pot lid. But because she was absent-minded and lifted it carelessly, her fingers touched the hot edge. The pain made her gasp, and she quickly put the lid back down, making a bang.

The kitchen suddenly became lively.

Unlike the quiet atmosphere from before, Liang Shi immediately put her fingers to her mouth and blew on them. Her fingernails were bright red.

Xu Qingzhu also heard the sound and turned to look. She saw Liang Shi with her eyes lowered, fingers near her mouth, gently blowing air on them.

From her angle, Liang Shi's long hair hung down and covered most of her face, making it impossible to see her expression clearly. But from her movements, one could tell... it really hurt.

Xu Qingzhu put down what she was holding and walked over to ask, "What happened?"

She immediately noticed her bright red fingertips and frowned, saying quietly, "How could you be so careless?"

Liang Shi pressed her lips together. "I forgot."

Her voice was very low, carrying a hint of sullenness. Xu Qingzhu took hold of her wrist and pushed up her sleeve.

The silver-white bracelet on her arm looked especially beautiful, making her skin appear even more fair. Xu Qingzhu's hands were small—she actually couldn't completely encircle Liang Shi's wrist in her palm.

Liang Shi's bright red fingertips were completely different from the color of her palm. Turning on the cold water, the water flowed over Liang Shi's reddened fingers.

Xu Qingzhu had her head lowered. Liang Shi suddenly said, "Xu Qingzhu, your hair has fallen down."

Xu Qingzhu didn't bother with it, only asking her, "Does it still hurt?"

Liang Shi shook her head, wanting to withdraw her fingers, but only managed to curl them a few times in Xu Qingzhu's hand without success.

Xu Qingzhu said, "Rinse it a bit more."

The cold water dissipated the burning heat from before. In the small space stood the two of them, their bodies close together. Liang Shi only had to turn her head slightly to see the ends of Xu Qingzhu's hair.

If there was anywhere on Xu Qingzhu that resembled Sheng Yu, it was probably her hair.

Both of them had fine, soft hair. Young Sheng Yu's hair color wasn't pure black either, but had a brownish tint—exactly like Xu Qingzhu's. When she grew up, she probably wouldn't even need to dye her hair.

The bright incandescent light illuminated this small space exceptionally well. Liang Shi's fingers were still held between Xu Qingzhu's, but her thoughts had already drifted off to who knows where—she could even space out while looking at Xu Qingzhu's hair.

Xu Qingzhu lowered her head and held her fingers under the cold water to rinse them. Only after confirming there was no major problem did she turn off the faucet. The sound of flowing water disappeared in an instant.

What remained in the kitchen was the small flame on the gas stove, the silver pot, and the congee inside constantly bubbling. Steam rose from the pot and dispersed throughout this small space, like the misty haze of a mountain morning—beautiful as if from a dream.

"I got Qi Jiao's diary today." Liang Shi was the first to speak, breaking the silence.

Xu Qingzhu tucked her hair back while putting on thick gloves to lift the pot lid. Her loose sleeves hung down, and the steam passed through her sleeves and landed on her skin.

"Rainbow gave it to you?"

Liang Shi nodded. "It's a diary written in Morse code."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

That was indeed surprising.

But what was even more surprising was, "Rainbow translated it?"

"She translated one page. The rest was translated by Big Brother." Liang Shi told Xu Qingzhu everything that had happened in the car earlier in full detail. Xu Qingzhu then looked at the diary entries she had typed in the notes app.

The kitchen fell quiet. After a long while, Xu Qingzhu suddenly smiled. "So warmth can be passed on after all."

Qi Jiao had once told Liang Shi that big sisters are supposed to protect little sisters.

Liang Shi had once said to her during their days of fleeing together that big sisters should protect little sisters.

Liang Shi didn't understand. "What do you mean?"

Xu Qingzhu smiled but didn't elaborate, directly changing the subject. "It's nothing. Teacher Liang, get the utensils. Time to eat."

Liang Shi was confused but didn't ask further.

She didn't know if Xu Qingzhu's cooking skills had improved, but her congee-making abilities had certainly progressed quite a bit, and she liked to make different kinds of congee.

Chapter 101-5

Both of them ate little for dinner. Sitting at the same dining table, neither spoke, quietly finishing their meal. Liang Shi went to clean up while Xu Qingzhu went to the bathroom to shower.

When she came out, she found Liang Shi sitting on the sofa with several sheets of paper spread out in front of her. The papers were covered with densely packed dots—someone who didn't know better would have thought it was someone's random doodles.

Liang Shi was using a translation app to re-translate, with a notebook and pen on her lap, neatly copying down the contents.

Xu Qingzhu asked, "Is this the original?"

"No." Liang Shi said, "This paper was torn from Rainbow's kindergarten lesson plan book. It should have been transcribed by Gu Xingyue."

What did Gu Xingyue want by giving her these?

A cry for help?

Liang Shi had been thinking about this question.

She didn't know what had happened to Gu Xingyue right now—whether she had been placed under strict surveillance by Yang Jiani again because of contacting her, or because her relationship with Cheng Ran had been exposed.

But it was also strange. Yang Jiani kept such strict watch over her that logically she should have imprisoned her at home, so why would she still let her go work at the kindergarten?

And back when Gu Xingyue took the college entrance exam, she had scored over six hundred points—clearly good enough to study in the capital city. Yet she stayed in Haizhou City to study early childhood education, wasting over a hundred points for nothing.

She had discussed this question with Xu Qingzhu before. They both leaned toward the idea that Gu Xingyue had made some kind of agreement with Yang Jiani while still in school and had been fighting for her own rights all along.

Although Gu Xingyue also seemed very gentle, as soft as water when dealing with children, she was different from Qi Jiao.

Qi Jiao had faced her own biological mother, oppression from childhood to adulthood. But Gu Xingyue had come into the picture later. To her, Yang Jiani was simply a crazy woman, and she was just trying to survive under a crazy woman's control.

So in a sense, Gu Xingyue would be braver than Qi Jiao, more intimidating to Yang Jiani and harder for her to control.

Liang Shi worked on these things until very late. Xu Qingzhu sat beside her with her laptop, leaning against the sofa and handling documents.

It wasn't until after ten o'clock at night that Liang Shi stretched and put everything away, then asked Xu Qingzhu, "Is Sheng Yu okay?"

"Yes." Xu Qingzhu said, "She didn't hit anything vital."

"That's good then." Liang Shi breathed a sigh of relief. Before she could say anything else, she yawned, her eyelids drooping, barely able to stay open.

Xu Qingzhu closed her laptop and comforted her. "Don't think so much. Go to sleep early. Wait until Monday to go check at the kindergarten entrance, or wait for Gu Xingyue to contact us. If you really can't wait, you can ask Sister-in-law to help. There's always a way."

"Mm-hmm." Liang Shi responded. She curled up on the sofa, her voice muffled. "I just feel sorry toward Gu Zhaoyuan."

She had already made arrangements with Gu Zhaoyuan. He had come to the city all excited, but ended up not seeing Gu Xingyue.

It felt like she had broken a promise.

Xu Qingzhu said helplessly, "Teacher Liang, can you please stop blaming yourself for everything? This was an accident to begin with. Why do you have to feel guilty even about something like this?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi sheepishly touched her nose. "Got it."

She looked like someone who had been scolded and was now dutifully heeding the lesson.

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

She thought her tone had been quite gentle, and she had spoken with the intention of comforting Liang Shi. Yet somehow Liang Shi seemed a bit aggrieved?

She wasn't sure if it was just her imagination.

After a while, Xu Qingzhu suddenly sat down beside her, very close. "Liang Shi, are you in a bad mood today?"

Liang Shi nodded, then shook her head. "It was okay at first, but after seeing Qi Jiao's diary, I couldn't suppress the sadness."

That kind of emotion—the more you deliberately try to suppress it, the more it rises.

You try to ignore it, only to find it's like a thorn that keeps pricking you, making it impossible to ignore.

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

She fell silent, because she realized she wasn't good at comforting people and didn't know where to start.

Compared to comforting, Xu Qingzhu was better at finding problems and solving them.

"Alright." Liang Shi stood up, stretched, and pretended to be nonchalant. "Let's sleep early. Everything will be fine when we wake up tomorrow. Oh right, Teacher Xu, the escape room we couldn't go to today—can we arrange it for tomorrow?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded. "Okay."

Then she also stood up and walked toward the master bedroom, preoccupied with thoughts. When she reached the doorway, she suddenly turned around, only to meet the gaze of Liang Shi, who had also suddenly turned around at the doorway of the second bedroom.

Liang Shi's expression showed she wanted to say something but hesitated. Xu Qingzhu also paused.

After a moment, Liang Shi asked in a muffled voice, "Xu Qingzhu, tonight... can I sleep with you?"

Her mission was about to fail. Even though this question was abrupt and shameless, she had no choice but to ask it thick-skinned.

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The question was very abrupt.

But Xu Qingzhu agreed.

Liang Shi carried her own blanket to Xu Qingzhu's room, then went to the bathroom to wash up. When she returned to the room after washing up, Xu Qingzhu was leaning against the headboard reading a book—a collection of English poetry with a blue cover in her hands.

Her fine, soft hair hung down, making her look peaceful and beautiful. Only in the instant she raised her eyes could one feel the coolness in her gaze.

But it was only for an instant. When she saw it was Liang Shi, her eyes curved slightly, everything natural and unforced.

This scene was like returning to when Liang Shi had just transmigrated. They had shared a room, and often when Liang Shi came out after showering, she would see Xu Qingzhu reading. Back then, her gaze was even more piercing than now, carrying a hidden hostility and disgust.

Although they shared the same bed, it was like being separated by the Milky Way—neither would touch the other throughout the entire night.

Back then, Xu Qingzhu slept very lightly, waking up at almost any sound, like a startled bird. But now she could calmly face Liang Shi, who was about to lie in the same bed with her.

She even felt a faint sense of anticipation.

Liang Shi's hair wasn't dry yet. Xu Qingzhu put down her book and called to her, "Bring the hair dryer over. I'll blow-dry it for you."

Liang Shi hesitated for a moment but listened to her. To make it more convenient for her, Liang Shi sat there lazily, her back hunched quite a bit. Xu Qingzhu sat on the bed and earnestly blow-dried her hair, her slender pale fingers threading through the brown strands. Liang Shi lowered her head and thought: How should I spend this long night?

There was still a key point to the system's mission: coax Xu Qingzhu to sleep by singing or telling a story.

Xu Qingzhu dried Liang Shi's hair until it was about seventy to eighty percent dry, then turned off the hair dryer. It suddenly became much quieter.

Xu Qingzhu lay back under the covers. Liang Shi went to put the hair dryer back in its place, then suddenly turned around and casually touched Xu Qingzhu's hair.

Xu Qingzhu chuckled softly. "It's already dry."

Liang Shi unconsciously smiled along with her. "It is dry."

When she returned from the bathroom again, the curtains in the room had been drawn tight, the main light had been turned off, leaving only the two dim lamps at the bedside.

Xu Qingzhu lay languidly on the bed, eyes half-closed, wearing a white spaghetti-strap nightgown. Her arms and upper body were exposed outside the covers, her forearms fair and slender. One could vaguely see her impressive curves.

Liang Shi: "....."

She walked over and pulled Xu Qingzhu's blanket up higher. Xu Qingzhu suddenly opened her eyes, her voice carrying a husky drowsiness. "Let's sleep."

Liang Shi responded with an "mm," then went around to the other side and carefully lay down, reaching out to turn off the lamp on her side.

Xu Qingzhu turned over, facing her. The soft light illuminated her entire face beautifully. She draped her arm over Liang Shi's body and said in a low voice, "Teacher Liang, sing a song."

Liang Shi: "?"